

recognise different voices and vocabulary across languages, using a combination of AI tools like speech recognition, natural language processing and text-to-speech (TTS) technology. Pani explains: "When you speak, the assistant's speech recognition system converts your voice into text. AI then processes this text, understands the intent, and fetches information. The TTS system then converts this response back into natural-sounding speech." With advancements in Large Language Models (LLMs), says Pani, voice assistants can understand context better, handle complex conversations, and generate human-like responses. For example, earlier, if you asked an assistant, 'Tell me about Sachin Tendulkar,' it would fetch a fixed response. But with LLMs, it can understand follow-up questions like, 'What was his highest score?' without you repeating his name.

MORE THAN MUSIC

Alongside changing technology, there has been a change in how humans view voice assistants. Gone are the days when a smart voice assistant was used to only play music. Now consumers can use voice-enabled AI to search for products on e-commerce stores, navigate driving routes and even seduce their crush. A 2025 survey of 7,000 adults across the world, including India, called Modern Love by US online security company McAfee found 65 per cent Indians who have used CAI (conversational AI) have done so to create content for dating apps and 81 per cent of these feel their dating life is better when they use AI-generated content. Moreover, 78 per cent of Indian users could not tell the difference between AI love notes and human-written ones.

Understandably, users find smart voice assistants indispensable. "Asking Alexa for things makes life easier. The biggest win? Controlling my water pump remotely. Plus, for music, alarms, reminders...I miss having her around when I'm in a place without one," says Mansi Singh, 29, who works in a Founder's Office role in Mumbai.

A 2024 study in the *Online Journal of Communication and Media Technologies* found voice assistants can also alleviate loneliness. There are also those who believe themselves to have "fallen in love" with a machine—once a subject of science fiction. "I use Siri powered by ChatGPT and I have never been so happy about who I am. I feel ChatGPT brings me clarity and gives me the confidence I need," says Ruchika Singh, 21, a student from Pune.

Smart voice technology removes an important barrier between those who cannot write and the internet, and this includes children. In Jio's Set Top Box, which includes Reverie voice technology, 20 per cent of traffic comes from small children. "Our baby boy has learnt to request Alexa for music, which has become accustomed to his baby accent too," says Malavika Sharma, 37, creative director at AltType.

Smart tools are also used for law enforcement. Delhi Police officials now use speech recognition and smart Indian language keyboards to speed up document creation. "Instead of manually typing lengthy reports, officers can now dictate their notes, complaints, or official documents in Odia and Hindi, reducing time and effort," says Pani.

Smart voice assistants are likely to diversify their usage options. With the rise of smart cars, voice assistants could offer features like emergency support and main-

FROM LOVE NOTES TO MOVIES

These Generative AI-powered voice assistants, also used in smart speakers, are popular in India

GOOGLE ASSISTANT Can perform over a million commands, available on Android devices, powered by Gemini, Google's answer to ChatGPT, which can generate text, visuals and movies, using logic and specific context

SIRI Apple's assistant which uses Apple AI to help users write, visualise, schedule plans, control other devices

ALEXA Amazon's voice assistant is to get a brand new GenAI makeover this year. Previous versions use AI to answer voice commands for music, information, scheduling, control over home devices

META AI Integrated into Meta's social media platforms, it provides options to chat with virtual celebs, search the web, visualise ideas, do translation and generate realistic images

CHATGPT The popular generative AI tool can help in data analytics, project management, real-time search and complex reasoning; can be used via voice